Chapter Twenty-One

Resentments

Between 1171 and 1186, Henry II of England fights the Irish, his own sons, and the French

By 1171, Henry II of England had recovered somewhat from his guilt over Becket's murder; at least, enough to invade Ireland.

He had been given an open door by the Irish king Diarmait Mac Murchada, ruler of the eastern kingdom of Leinster. Leinster, as the thirteenth-century historian Gerald of Wales points out, was "separated only from England by the sea which flowed between," making it a natural target for the English. But Henry's path into it was indirect. A few years before, Mac Murchada had rashly visited the wife of the neighboring king of Meath, in her husband's absence; she had "long entertained a passion" for Mac Murchada, Gerald assures us, "and allowed herself to be ravished, not against her will." The king of Meath, returning home, was not pleased. He gathered his own men together and then called on the High King of Ireland to help him avenge his honor.[1]

The High King of Ireland was Rory O'Connor, king of Connacht. For centuries, one Irish king out of the handful that ruled the island had borne the title of High King. But, as contemporary historians point out, the designated High King was always ruler *co fresabra*: with opposition. The High King's authority was constantly challenged by his peers, and Rory O'Connor was no